

A TEMPTATION OR A TEST?

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: **Matthew 4:1-11** (NKJV) *“Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. ² And when He had fasted forty days and forty nights, afterward He was hungry. ³ Now when the tempter came to Him, he said, ‘If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread.’ ⁴ But He answered and said, ‘It is written, ‘Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds from the mouth of God.’” ⁵ Then the devil took Him up into the holy city, set Him on the pinnacle of the temple, ⁶ and said to Him, “If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down. For it is written: ‘He shall give His angels charge over you,’ and, ‘In their hands they shall bear you up, Lest you dash your foot*

against a stone.””⁷ Jesus said to him, “It is written again, ‘You shall not tempt the LORD your God.’”⁸ Again, the devil took Him up on an exceedingly high mountain, and showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory.⁹ And he said to Him, “All these things I will give You if You will fall down and worship me.”¹⁰ Then Jesus said to him, “Away with you, Satan! For it is written, ‘You shall worship the LORD your God, and Him only you shall serve.’”¹¹ Then the devil left Him, and behold, angels came and ministered to Him.”

INTRO: The story of the temptation of Jesus seems to have a strange setting indeed. A baptismal service was being conducted in the Jordan River and John the Baptist was the name of the minister performing the ordinance of water baptism. John was not cut from the cloth of normal priestly protocol quite the contrary is true: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- His message was a departure from the norm - His was a message of repentance.
- His attire was anything but fashionable - A camels skin suit held in place by a leather girdle.
- His diet was shocking - His favorite meal was grasshoppers and wild honey.

John was the Grizzly Adams of the religious right. He was a terrible fashion disaster whose diet was never copied.

A phenomenon unlike anything the current religious leaders had ever saw was beginning to occur, though his habits were terribly unorthodox and his message anything but consoling, great multitudes followed the ministry of John The Baptist. The impact of his ministry would be such, that the effects of it would be felt for more than two thousand years.

Immediately following the baptism of one of the candidates John looked up to see a young man approaching from the distant horizon. As the man drew nearer John recognized the familiar stride of his cousin, Jesus Christ. In his attempt to exchange pleasantries with Jesus, John utters words that would become an historic anomaly and a prophetic benchmark; "***Behold the lamb of God which taketh away the sins of the world.***" Everyone in the crowd caught and held their breath; exchanged glances of wonder; and were apparently shocked at the bold statement of this wilderness preacher. John was certainly not one who made a habit of mincing words or beating around the bush but this was an uncharacteristically bold statement, even for John.

Every Jewish person gathered in this small group of converts was very well rehearsed with regard to the work of the sacrificial lamb on the Day of Atonement. In his

declaration of his Cousin Jesus' arrival, John not only declared Jesus to be a lamb but ***"THE Lamb of God"*** that would ***"TAKE AWAY the sins of the world."*** John was declaring that Jesus would attain a threshold of achievement that no other lamb for centuries past had been able to attain, though they had given their very lives. The work of the lamb that John was speaking of would be to forgive sin - not just roll them ahead a year at a time. For all practical purposes John declared Jesus to be the Messiah!

Following such an announcement, you would expect Jesus to:

- Pull together a ministry team...
- Write a book...
- Develop a magazine...
- Establish a television ministry
- Build a base of support...

In short, do the things that are generally expected and necessary to begin a ministry

that is capable of touching the entire earth. True to His unconventional model of ministry Jesus does nothing of the sort; In fact, He seems to downplay the announcement by requesting to be baptized by this rugged wilderness preacher.

Upon His baptism, a wonderful phenomenon occurred involving a dove, defying its nature to make physical contact with a human being, and a voice booming from the sky saying *"This is my beloved son in whom I am well pleased."*

This is the stuff wildly popular movies and superstars are made of. The really shocking feature of this entire story is what happens next: Jesus is *"Led of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil."*

The expectation of the casual reader is for Jesus to: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Maximize the moment...
- Strike while the iron was hot...
- Capitalize on the occasion...

But He does nothing of the sort; He goes into seclusion! What a waste of momentum! Can you imagine such a thing? And He is doing all of this at the instruction of the Spirit.

The picture becomes extremely vague over the next forty days but we do know Jesus passed the time fasting and praying and in fellowship with the father. Following this forty-day rendezvous with God Jesus emerges from His sabbatical only to be met by a direct assault from Satan himself. The events that follow are commonly referred to as the "*Temptation of Jesus*".

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN TEMPTATION AND TESTING

The "*Temptation of Jesus*" is not what most people have believed it to be. There is certainly more to it than would be immediately apparent to the casual reader or somewhat distracted observer. This temptation could probably be better described as the "*Testing of Jesus*".

A more in-depth look at these two words reveals a Scriptural truth that has been almost totally ignored. **Temptation is always self-inflicted just as testing is allowed by our Heavenly Father for the purpose of: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Strengthening us...
- Building our faith...
- Preparing us for greatness...
- Developing character that can stand the onslaught of success and failure...

On the other hand, temptation as we know it, the enticement to do evil: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Does not build our faith...
- Does not better prepare us for success or failure...
- Is destructive to our character...

The motive of this kind of temptation is: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- To entice us to do evil...
- Terminate our influence...
- Separate us from close fellowship with God...
- Destroy the destiny God has called us to...

The testing of Jesus did not have anything to do with a moral lapse but had everything to do with the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life. 1 John 2:15-17 (NKJV) *"Do not love the world or the*

things in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him.16 For all that is in the world—the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life—is not of the Father but is of the world.17 And the world is passing away, and the lust of it; but he who does the will of God abides forever." The lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life, has to do with **the three-part composition of man: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Body
- Soul
- Spirit

The testing of Jesus consisted of the following: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The lust of the flesh - He had not received nourishment for his body for forty days, and the first thing the enemy

attempted to do was entice Him to use His supernatural ability to satisfy the flesh side of His nature. ***“If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread.”*** Was He hungry? He was starving! I have heard individuals who were attempting to sound super spiritual say they fasted for several days and never experienced hunger! I have fasted extensively for many years, fasting at one point thirty days, drinking only water (losing 47 pounds in 30 days), and I can tell you that I craved food I otherwise didn't even like. People who fast and do not get hungry are either far more spiritual than Jesus, they are lying, or they are sneaking around and eating in private. Jesus was hungry and this was a test of the flesh. After forty days of fasting Jesus' flesh was no doubt screaming for nourishment. The enemy tested Jesus' commitment by attempting

to get Him to use his supernatural abilities to satisfy the flesh.

- **The Lust of the eyes** - Satan tried to entice Jesus to cast himself down from the pinnacle of the temple, thus falling into a trap of using His divine connections and heightened spiritual awareness to do something that would defy natural and divine law. ***“If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down. For it is written: ‘He shall give His angels charge over you,’ and, ‘In their hands they shall bear you up, Lest you dash your foot against a stone.’”*** In so doing He would have been guilty of using His powers to appeal to the senses. Our Souls consist of our mind, will, and emotions. Unless we properly control our mind, will, and emotions through the power of the Holy Spirit we tend to become more sensual than spiritual. When we allow the sensual to prevail over the spiritual, we are by an act of our

own will stepping outside the protection and provision of God. When we step outside the protection and provision of God we become drawn away of our own lust, caving in to temptation. This is a test of the sensual side of Jesus. The enemy was attempting to entice Him into the spectacular at a time of super spirituality. Jesus would have no part of it because He knew that a propensity to the sensual never satisfies the appetite of the eye. Jesus understood that if He jumped from the pinnacle of the Temple and Angels carried Him safely to the earth the sensual rush would never satisfy, but leave Him lusting for more. All attempts to satisfy the soul leave the individual lusting for more.

- **The pride of life** - Satan continues the test by attempting to appeal to the spiritual side of Jesus by leading Him to a high mountain and telling Him if He would bow down and worship, he would

give Him all He could see. ***“Then Jesus said to him, “Away with you, Satan! For it is written, ‘You shall worship the LORD your God, and Him only you shall serve.’”*** The spiritual side of every person is destined to rule as a king and priest. Because we are destined to rule as kings and priests every believer has a natural bent to worship and reign. This can get us into trouble if we worship the wrong things and try to reign over territory we are not called to. Because we have a predisposition for worshipping and reigning many of the tests that come our way will be spiritual in nature. The enemy consistently attempts to keep us from becoming all we can be in the spiritual realm and then uses our lack of perceived progress as a catalyst to convince us to give up on our destiny. Jesus had a leg up on the tempter because he was fully aware that what he was offering was not his to give.

This was an illusion as are all the enemy's claims of entitlement or bestowment.

THE VULNERABILITY OF TEMPTATION

James 1:12-15 (NKJV) *"Blessed is the man who endures temptation; for when he has been approved, he will receive the crown of life which the Lord has promised to those who love Him.13 Let no one say when he is tempted, "I am tempted by God"; for God cannot be tempted by evil, nor does He Himself tempt anyone.14 But each one is tempted when he is drawn away by his own desires and enticed.15 Then, when desire has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and sin, when it is full-grown, brings forth death."*

James 1:12-15 (LB) *"Happy is the man who doesn't give in and do wrong when he is tempted, for afterwards he will get as his reward the crown of life that God has*

promised those who love him. 13 And remember, when someone wants to do wrong it is never God who is tempting him, for God never wants to do wrong and never tempts anyone else to do it. 14 Temptation is the pull of man's own evil thoughts and wishes. 15 These evil thoughts lead to evil actions and afterwards to the death penalty from God."

There are three basic temptations or tests that we all face: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Things God allows** - This testing has its limits and our spiritual growth and character have been pre-tested and deemed sufficient for the test. I see no record in Scripture of anyone failing a test that was pre-approved by God. (Job) 1 Corinthians 10:13 (NKJV) *"No temptation has overtaken you except such as is common to man; but God is faithful, who will not allow you to be tempted beyond what you are able, but*

with the temptation will also make the way of escape, that you may be able to bear it."

- **Things Satan designs** - God will never sanction a test that allows for a moral failure. The enemy cannot force you to sin; the devil did not make you do it! He can do no more than make a brief presentation of the temptation. (King David)
- **Self-inflicted temptation** - By our own volition and imagination we take the bait of Satan and imagine our way into a situation that we are powerless to win (Samson). Son of Manoah - Angel announced his birth - He was to be a Nazarite - He was to be a deliverer for Israel - The angel of the Lord ascended in the flame from a meat offering - The Spirit of the Lord moved upon him from time to time - Judges 14:1(NKJV) *"Now Samson went down to Timnath, and saw a woman in Timnath of the*

daughters of the Philistines." He killed 30 men to get garments to give to the men of Timnath – He caught 300 foxes, set their tails on fire, and burned the Philistines corn crop up – He slew a host of Philistines hip and thigh - With the jaw bone of an ass he slew 1,000 Philistines - After this slaughter Samson was famished from thirst and God hollowed out a place in the jawbone from which water gushed forth, quenching his thirst - He frequented a prostitute in Gaza - He carried away the gates of the city of Gaza – In Judges 16:4 he meets Delilah - Breaks green vines that had never been dried - Breaks new ropes - Carries away a beam fastened to his head with a pin - He tells all - Delilah sold him out - He lost his power with God – He was blinded and made a circus attraction - He was made to grind at the enemies wheel – Upon his request God restored his unusual strength.

Temptation, as we know it, has to do with an enticement to do that which is in direct moral conflict with Biblical standards and practices. (Lying - stealing - cheating - etc.)

According to the Word, God cannot be tempted by these things and will not authorize such an attack against us! **James 1:13-15 (LB) "*And remember, when someone wants to do wrong it is never God who is tempting him, for God never wants to do wrong and never tempts anyone else to do it. 14 Temptation is the pull of man's own evil thoughts and wishes. 15 These evil thoughts lead to evil actions and afterwards to the death penalty from God.*" (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

I think we could safely say that any attack against us that has attached to it an enticement to do that which is not morally convenient, is from Satan himself. If the

attack carries these illegal components, it is a covert attack and must be dealt with as such. In fighting against such an attack we should use all the weapons at our disposal. Throw the book (the Bible) at the devil! This kind of attack is normally won or lost at the point of impact.

As we look into this verse the one thing that becomes very apparent; temptation is often self-inflicted testing is not! ***"Every man is tempted WHEN he is drawn away of his own lust and enticed."***

The fact that many of us struggle so unsuccessfully is proof that we are either acting on the thoughts the enemy has placed in our mind or we are suffering a self-inflicted temptation.

Almost unknowingly many Christians willingly place themselves in vulnerable positions. Others fail to implement a *"Search and destroy"* mentality during initial impact.

Either way we become vulnerable to the enemy who is absolutely merciless when he discovers the helplessness of his victim.

THE PROTECTION OF TESTING

You are probably thinking that Jesus faced the same temptations we do yet He did not sin. This is true; the Bible states it very vigorously. [Hebrews 4:15](#) (NKJV) *"For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin."* Hebrews 4:15 (LB) *"This High Priest of ours understands our weaknesses since he had the same temptations we do, though he never once gave way to them and sinned."*

So [what kind of temptation did Jesus face?](#)
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- He was restricted by the limitations of the flesh - He became hungry - Matthew 4 (Turn these stones into bread), this was the first way the enemy tested Him.
- He became physically exhausted - Several times in Scripture He removed Himself from the crowd for some rest and relaxation.
- He became lonely - *"Foxes have holes, birds have nests, but the son of man does not have a place to lay His head."*
- He suffered rejection - The betrayal of Judas. The night prior to the crucifixion Jesus was agonizing in prayer and the disciples could not stay awake with Him for one hour - We can almost hear the rejection in Jesus' voice as He say's *"Sleep on now."*
- He endured conflict within His family – Mary and Joseph looking for Him after He had been gone three days.

- He was tempted to get angry and lose His temper - Dealing with the mercenaries in the Temple.
- He suffered physical pain - His crucifixion.

Though Jesus was tested in many ways, there is not one shred of evidence in the Bible that He was tempted to do anything in conflict with Biblical standards or practices!

- He was never tempted to relegate God to anything but first place in His life!
- He was never tempted to commit idolatry!
- He was never tempted to serve any God but Jehovah!
- He was never tempted to curse!
- He was never tempted to dishonor the Lord's Day!
- He was never tempted to dishonor His parents!

- He was never tempted to take an innocent life!
- He never lusted after another man's wife!
- He was never tempted to take anything that did not belong to Him!
- He was never tempted to covet another man's possessions!

Did the idea of doing any of these things ever enter into the mind of Jesus? I'm sure it did, but He knew the power of casting imaginations down upon impact.

This is where our battle with the devil is won or lost. If we allow the mental process to go beyond an initial thought we have stepped outside the protection God has so graciously provided. When we allow ourselves to step outside His protection and provision we are no match for the devil. Just as Jesus overcame the temptation to do wrong, if we will cast every thought of

immorality and unscriptural practice down upon impact we will never be tempted to do these things either!

In the Old Testament Job experienced a test - not a temptation - a test! The test Job faced was actually brought on by the fact God was bragging about Job's integrity and spiritual maturity. God said to the devil ***"Have you noticed my servant Job? He is the finest man in all the earth — a good man who fears God and will have nothing to do with evil."*** Job 1:8 (LB) Considering the overall story of the testing of Job it is obvious; all that came against him had to first of all meet the approval of God. That sounds strange indeed but it is nonetheless true! Job 23:10 (NKJV) ***"But He knows the way that I take; When He has tested me, I shall come forth as gold."***

The tests we face come as no surprise to God. They sometimes hit us broadside but they never catch God off guard.

Every test we face must meet the approval of God in advance. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

God looks at the test and then looks at where we are and what we are capable of enduring in the physical, emotional, and spiritual realm. In this process He considers our faith and endurance and would never allow the enemy to bring anything against us that we are incapable of handling. *"No testing has overtaken you that is not common to everyone. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tested beyond your strength, but with the testing he will also provide the way out so that you may be able to endure it."*

There is no way of getting around it or avoiding it, the fact is God allowed this test to come into Job's life - He could have prevented it but He did not choose to do so.

Why do you suppose God chose such a course of action?

He was strengthening Job; building his faith; preparing him for a time of success and greatness that was beyond his wildest imagination. Job was about to be given twice as much as he had before the test; twice as many children; twice as many cattle and oxen; twice as many resources; twice as much life! Job was seventy years old at the onset of the test, and he lived to be two hundred and ten years old!

When we stop to think about it, Job was enduring a test that he could not fail because God had already examined the test and evaluated Job's integrity and spiritual maturity. The enemy initiated a battle that he was predisposed to lose from the beginning.

Testing has to do with living in right relationship with God and others regardless

of the pressure to do otherwise. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Testing also has to do with standing on the promises of God despite the temptation to do otherwise. To the person who is tested by God the highest form of reality is what the Word of God has to say on the subject.

In the testing of Jesus He took three scriptures out of the Old Testament book of Deuteronomy and whipped the devil all over the desert. I am convinced that God looked at the test and then at His son Jesus and said something like this to an angel; *"This should be good; Satan wants to test Jesus by offering Him food, sensationalism, and power! What a dumb devil, doesn't he know who Jesus is and where He has been?"* By the way, we are also sons of God and have been given the same rights, privileges and power as Jesus had when He was upon the earth.

The bottom line here is temptation has everything to do with our own lusts and appetites, testing has to do with our personal development and spiritual maturity.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) When we are working our way through a test rather than a temptation the sounds, sights, and smell of victory are never beyond our reach!

PRACTICAL APPLICATION

The key to our success in any test we face is as follows: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Live within the hedge of protection God has cast for us. The hedge consists of the Blood of Jesus and the Word of God. As long as we live our lives within those perimeters we have nothing to fear from the enemy. He can't win and we can't lose!

- Never allow the devil to entice us to step outside the Bloodline. We must never allow him to convince us that even though the Word of God speaks out against a certain behavior God will make an exception for us.